

DINNER · POPPY'S KITCHEN

# Spinach & Cottage Cheese Baked Pasta

*A lazy lasagna: creamy, cheesy, high-protein baked pasta with spinach hiding in plain sight.*

| | |
|---|---|
| **4, plus a lunch** SERVES | **50 min** START TO TABLE |
| **15 min** PREP | **35 min** COOK |

**Weeknight bake**

## 🛒 What you need

FROM THE STORE

- ☐ **1 lb** Pasta (rotini or penne)
- ☐ **1 jar** Rao's marinara
- ☐ **2 cups** Cottage cheese
- ☐ **5 oz** Baby spinach, chopped
- ☐ **1** Egg
- ☐ **2 cups** Tillamook mozzarella, shredded
- ☐ **½ cup** Grated parmesan
- ☐ **3 cloves** Garlic, minced

FROM THE PANTRY

- ☐ **1 Tbsp** Olive oil
- ☐ **1 tsp** Italian seasoning
- ☐ Salt and pepper

⚡ **First:** Oven to 400°F and the pasta water on.

GEAR

Big pot · 9×13 dish · Big bowl

## 🔥 Let's cook

1. Heat the oven to 400°F. Boil the pasta 2 minutes less than the box says. Drain. ⏱️ 10 min
2. While it boils, cook the garlic in the oil 30 seconds, add the spinach and stir until wilted. ⏱️ 2 min
3. In a big bowl mix the cottage cheese, egg, half the parmesan, Italian seasoning, salt and pepper. 🧒 Kids can do this
4. Fold in the spinach, the pasta, 2 cups marinara and 1 cup mozzarella. 🧒 Kids can do this
5. Spread in a 9×13. Spoon the rest of the sauce on top, then the last mozzarella and parmesan. 🧒 Kids can do this
6. Bake 20 minutes until bubbly; broil 2 minutes for brown spots. Rest 5 minutes. ⏱️ 22 min

👨‍🍳 **CHEF'S SECRET**

Undercook the pasta by 2 minutes. It finishes in the oven soaking up sauce, so it ends up just right instead of mushy.



DINNER · FLIP SIDE

# Spinach & Cottage Cheese Baked Pasta

## 👩‍🍳 Kitchen crew: kid jobs

- [ ] Crack the egg into the cottage cheese and stir
- [ ] Tear up the spinach
- [ ] Spread it in the dish and add the cheese on top
- [ ] Set out parmesan for the table

Knives, the stove and the oven: a grown-up stays right there. Steps marked 🧒 **Kids can do this** on the front are theirs to own.

### ⏰ MAKE IT AHEAD

Assemble a day ahead (fridge, covered); bake 30 minutes.

### 🥡 LEFTOVERS

Reheats better than it starts. Perfect lunch.

### 🔁 SWAP IT

- Barilla Protein+ pasta for even more protein
- Ricotta instead of cottage cheese
- Add browned Italian sausage

### 🍽️ SERVE IT WITH

Spring mix with Italian dressing, garlic toast

## ⏱️ Game plan: everything lands at once

| | |
|---|---|
| **50 min out** | Oven to 400°F. Pasta water on to boil. |
| **40 min** | Pasta in. Wilt the spinach with garlic. Kids mix the cheese filling. |
| **32 min** | Drain. Kids fold it all together and fill the 9×13. |
| **27 min** | Into the oven for 20 min, then 2 min under the broiler. |
| **5 min** | Rest so it slices clean. |
| **Dinner** | Serve with a salad or garlic toast. |

## Done cooking? Tell Poppy how it went.

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